ClipStage v7 - Installation Guide

macOS and Windows · middle machine and editor computers · version 7.0.0

Contents

1. At a glance
2. What is new in v7
3. Before you start
4. Middle machine: Mac
5. Middle machine: Windows
6. Editor computer: Mac
7. Editor computer: Windows
8. First launch (Volumes box)
9. Day-to-day use
10. Upgrade an existing install
11. Test checklist
12. If something does not work
13. Rollback
14. What is verified, and what is not
15. Quick reference

---

1. At a glance

ClipStage has two kinds of computer. The **middle machine** (one per newsroom) runs search, the API, the indexer and keeps every editor's staging list. An **editor computer** opens ClipStage, stages clips and drags them into the editing software. Every installer is one command, asks only what it cannot know, and is safe to run again.

	Mac	Windows
Middle machine	`bash install-mac-host.sh`	`powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File .\install-win-host.ps1`
Editor computer	`bash install-mac-editor.sh --host <middle-machine-ip>`	paste the **one line** the middle machine's installer prints
Drag into	Final Cut Pro	Premiere / Resolve / Avid (drag not yet verified, see section 14)
Project folder	`~/Documents/ClipStage`	`C:\ClipStage`
Open in a browser	`http://<middle-machine-ip>:8000`	`http://<middle-machine-ip>:8000`

> **Note.** Use the same system on both sides: a Mac middle machine with Mac editors, or a Windows middle machine with Windows editors. Mixing the two is not set up or tested.

---

2. What is new in v7

- **Staging is a list, not a folder.** Each editor's staged clips are rows in a database table inside `clipstage.db`. There is no staging folder, no staging share and no symlinks on the middle machine.
- **Editors no longer log in to the middle machine over SMB.** The app reads the list over HTTP (port 8000). It only needs the NAS shares mounted.
- **Volumes box (once per computer).** The middle machine calls a share **EDIT**; on your Mac it may be **EDIT-1**. You confirm that once and the app remembers it. Nothing is used until you confirm.
- **A red dot says why** a clip cannot be dragged (volume not mounted, file not found, no permission, removed from the index).
- **Backup route on Mac:** a local folder of links (`~/ClipStage/<NAME>`) with an **Open local folder** link, for when dragging from the app does not work.
- **One code base for Mac and Windows:** the same app runs on both; only the path style differs.
- **The app window is locked to the ClipStage server:** no popups, no navigating away; only approved links open in the system browser.
- **Windows editors no longer need any Windows link setting** (the old installer changed a Windows network-security setting; v7 does not).

---

3. Before you start

- The ClipStage folder (unzip `ClipStage-v7.zip`).
- Supabase **Project URL** and **anon/publishable key** (Supabase, Project Settings, API). **Not** the service-role key.
- The **NAS address**, a NAS login (domain, user, password) and the share names (the default list is in `.env.sample`: EDIT, EDIT2, INGEST, PLAYOUT, DIGITAL, SHARE FOLDER, TRANSCODER).
- Internet access on the machine (it downloads Python, ffmpeg, Typesense and more).
- An administrator account on the machine.
- The middle machine's **IP address**, and a fixed address for it if you can (editors connect to it).

Every installer first shows a **plan** (what is installed and what will be). Answer **N** and nothing is changed. It then shows your entries; type **C** to confirm or **E** to edit.

---

4. Middle machine: Mac (new install)

1. Unzip `ClipStage-v7.zip` (for example in Downloads) and open **Terminal**.
2. Run:

```
cd ~/Downloads/ClipStage
bash install-mac-host.sh
```

3. Read the plan, answer the questions (Supabase, NAS, volumes, editor names), then type **C**. Enter your Mac password when asked. It takes about 10 to 20 minutes the first time.
4. It installs Homebrew (only if missing), Python, ffmpeg and Typesense, writes `.env` (owner-only, with a new random Typesense key), mounts the NAS, installs three background services (API at login, nightly index and backup at 17:00, NAS watchdog), checks `/health` and offers to start the first index.
5. The project is moved to `~/Documents/ClipStage` if you ran it from Downloads or Desktop.
6. **Logins:** the installer copies the SQL to your clipboard and opens Supabase. Create users (Authentication, Users, Add user), run `supabase_profiles_setup.sql`, and give each user a role and expiry.
7. Open `http://<this-mac-ip>:8000` from another computer and sign in.

> **Tip.** v7 does **not** create a staging folder or turn on macOS File Sharing for staging. (Only if you still need the old folder during a transition: `CLIPSTAGE_LEGACY_STAGING=1 bash install-mac-host.sh`.)

Everyday commands, run in the project folder: `./clipstage.sh status | restart | logs | index | stop-index | backup | open`

---

5. Middle machine: Windows (new install)

1. Unzip `ClipStage-v7.zip` and open **PowerShell** (any window).
2. Go to the ClipStage folder and run:

```
powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File .\install-win-host.ps1
```

3. Accept the administrator prompt. Answer the same questions as on the Mac (Supabase, NAS, volumes, editor names) and confirm.
4. It installs Python, ffmpeg and Typesense (Typesense runs inside a small dedicated WSL2 Linux, because it has no native Windows build), builds the environment, sets up NAS access (`C:\Volumes\<share>`), the firewall rules, the background tasks and an **editor kit**.
5. **Windows may restart once** the first time if WSL2 was not on. The installer continues by itself after you sign in again. Do nothing.
6. At the end it prints **one line** to paste on each editor PC (see section 7). Print it again any time with `cd C:\ClipStage; .\clipstage.ps1 editor-kit`.
7. Do the Supabase logins step (same as the Mac), then open `http://<this-pc-ip>:8000`.

- Project: `C:\ClipStage`. Tools: `C:\ClipStage-tools`. Install log: `C:\ClipStage-install.log`.
- Everyday: `cd C:\ClipStage; .\clipstage.ps1 status` (also `start, stop, restart, logs, index, stop-index, backup, open`).

> **Note.** v7 does **not** create the staging folder or staging share. It still creates a small read-only **`clipstage-editor`** account and the **`clipstage-setup`** share, because editor PCs use them to fetch the installer. (Legacy only: add `-LegacyStaging` to also create the old staging share.)

---

6. Editor computer: Mac

1. Copy the ClipStage folder to the editor Mac (or unzip `ClipStage-v7.zip` there).
2. In Terminal:

```
cd ~/Downloads/ClipStage
bash install-mac-editor.sh --host <middle-machine-ip>
```

3. It mounts the NAS shares as `/Volumes/<share>`, keeps them mounted (every 5 minutes and at login), and installs `/Applications/ClipStage.app`. It asks for the NAS login if needed.
4. In **Final Cut Pro**: Settings, Import, Files, tick **Leave files in place** (once).
5. Open **ClipStage** from Applications and go to section 8.

- Options: `--no-app` (browser only), `--reconfigure` (ask again, rebuild the app).
- Running it again is safe. It rebuilds the app when the app version or the middle machine's address changed.
- There is no staging share and no staging login on the editor Mac in v7.

---

7. Editor computer: Windows

1. On the middle machine, make sure the install finished (section 5). It printed one line; reprint it with `.\clipstage.ps1 editor-kit`.
2. On the editor PC, open PowerShell and paste that line. It looks like:

```
cmdkey /add:10.1.10.5 /user:MIDDLEPC\clipstage-editor /pass:<password>; powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File
\\10.1.10.5\clipstage-setup\install-win-editor.ps1
```

3. Accept the administrator prompt. It checks that the middle machine answers, asks for the editor's NAS login (skip if the PC already reaches the NAS), connects `C:\Volumes\<share>` to the NAS shares (same names as on the middle machine), installs Node.js and the ClipStage app, and puts a **ClipStage shortcut on the desktop**.
4. Open ClipStage from the desktop and go to section 8.

> **Careful.** The pasted line contains the editors' read-only setup password. Treat it like a password. It is also saved in `C:\ClipStage\editor-kit\editor-config.json` on the middle machine.

- Options: `-NoApp` (browser only), `-Reconfigure` (ask for the NAS login again). Log: `%TEMP%\clipstage-editor-install.log`.
- The local links folder is **off on Windows**. Use drag, **Copy path** or the browser if drag does not work.

---

8. First launch on an editor computer (Volumes box)

The middle machine stores every clip with **its** volume names (for example `/Volumes/EDIT/2026/clip.mxf`). Your computer may call the same share something else. The app asks once and remembers the answer.

1. Open ClipStage, sign in, and choose your name in the editor list.
2. Click **Volumes on this computer** (the button above the staging list). Each host volume the app can see is listed.
3. For each volume the app offers what it found. Click **Yes, use it** if it is right. If several folders match, pick the right one. If it is wrong or missing, click **Choose folder...** and pick the share's folder (on Windows, for example `C:\Volumes\EDIT`).
4. Done. Use **Change...** or **Forget** later if a share moves.

> **Tip.** Nothing is dragged from a volume until you confirm it, so a wrong guess never opens the wrong file. Volumes your computer does not have are not shown unless a staged clip needs them.

---

9. Day-to-day use

1. **Search**, select one or many clips, click **Stage Clips**. Each clip becomes one row in your staging list.
2. **Drag** a staged card (click cards first to select several, Shift-click for a range) onto the editing software's timeline. You can also drag a search result straight from the results without staging.
3. **Remove** one clip with the cross on its card, or use **Clear**. Only the list changes. Footage is never touched.
4. **Copy path** (the small copy button on a card) copies the clip's path. In a plain browser this is how you get a path, because dragging needs the desktop app.

What the dot and the message mean

Dot / message	Meaning	Fix
Green	The file is reachable from this computer	-
Grey	Not checked yet (the app is still checking)	Wait a moment
Volume not set up	This share has not been confirmed in the Volumes box	Volumes box, Yes, use it
Volume not mounted	The NAS share is not connected on this computer	Mount it (the installer's watchdog retries every 5 minutes on Mac)
File not found here	The share is there but the file is not	The clip was moved or deleted on the NAS

No permission	This login cannot read the file	Check the NAS login / share access
Removed from the index	The indexer no longer lists this clip	Remove it from staging
Hidden by an admin	An admin hid the clip	Ask an admin

If dragging from the app does not work (Mac)

Click **Open local folder** (shown in the staging bar when the app keeps one). Finder opens `~/ClipStage/<NAME>`, which holds links to the real NAS files. Drag from there into Final Cut Pro. Two different clips with the same file name are kept apart as `name.mxf` and `name__2.mxf`.

---

10. Upgrade an existing install (5.1.3, 5.1.4 or v6-dev)

Do the middle machine first, then each editor computer. The old editor app does not understand the v7 page, so upgrade each editor computer the same day (until then an editor can use a browser, where search and staging still work).

Middle machine: Mac

1. **Back up** from your current project folder:

```
cd ~/Documents/ClipStage
./clipstage.sh backup
mkdir -p ~/clipstage-backup && cp .env clipstage.db editors.json ~/clipstage-backup/
```

2. Unzip `ClipStage-v7.zip` in Downloads. **Delete the `editors.json` inside the unzipped folder** so your own editor list is not overwritten.
3. Run the installer from the new folder. It copies over `~/Documents/ClipStage`, keeps your `.env`, `clipstage.db` and index, and restarts the services:

```
cd ~/Downloads/ClipStage
bash install-mac-host.sh
```

4. Import the old staged clips (they are links in `/Users/Shared/staging`). First a dry run, then apply:

```
cd ~/Documents/ClipStage
.venv/bin/python migrate_staging_to_db.py
.venv/bin/python migrate_staging_to_db.py --apply
```

5. Open `http://<mac-ip>:8000`, sign in, stage a clip and confirm it appears. Check `/Users/Shared/staging` got no new link.
6. After every editor is on v7, optionally remove the old **staging** share: System Settings, General, Sharing, File Sharing.

> **Tip.** The importer only reads the old folders. It backs up `clipstage.db` first, deletes nothing and is safe to re-run.

Middle machine: Windows

1. Back up `C:\ClipStage\.env`, `clipstage.db` and `editors.json` to another folder.
2. Unzip `ClipStage-v7.zip` and run `powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File .\install-win-host.ps1` from the new folder. It copies to `C:\ClipStage` without touching `.env`, the database, the index or `editors.json`, and rebuilds the editor kit with the v7 app.
3. The staging importer is written for the Mac host and has **not** been verified on Windows. Staging lists are short-lived: ask editors to stage again.

Each editor computer

- **Mac:** copy the new ClipStage folder to the Mac and run `bash install-mac-editor.sh --host <middle-machine-ip>`. The old app is replaced. Then do section 8 (Volumes box) once.
- **Windows:** on the middle machine run `.\clipstage.ps1 editor-kit`, then paste the printed line on the editor PC (section 7). Then do section 8 once.

---

11. Test checklist (about 15 minutes)

Tick each box. Do the Mac and Windows lists on a real editor computer of that type. **Items 6 to 9 have never been run on real hardware; record the result.**

	Check	Expected
☐	Middle machine: `./clipstage.sh status` or `.\clipstage.ps1 status`	API, Typesense and index running
☐	Browser to `http://<ip>:8000`, sign in, search, stage a clip	Clip appears in the staging list
☐	Look for a new file in the old staging folder	None (v7 writes nothing there)

☐	Editor computer: install, open the app, Volumes box, confirm each volume	Green dot on the staged clip
☐	Unmount one NAS share, refresh	Red: Volume not mounted. Green again after remount
☐	**Drag one staged clip** into the editing software timeline	Imported; file size equals the NAS file; media **not copied** (Leave in place)
☐	**Drag three staged clips at once**	All three arrive
☐	**Drag one search result** (not staged)	Arrives
☐	Mac only: **Open local folder**, drag a link from Finder into FCP	Imports the real file (your proven fallback)
☐	Remove one clip with the cross, then Clear	List updates; NAS untouched
☐	Second editor name: stage there, switch name	Lists are separate

12. If something does not work

Symptom	Fix
Browser says "site can't be reached"	Check the middle machine is on and `CLIPSTAGE_BIND_HOST=0.0.0.0` in `.env`; the firewall allows port 8000
App drag does nothing, popup mentions Volumes	Open the Volumes box and confirm that volume (section 8)
Red: Volume not mounted	Mount the NAS share on this computer; on Mac the watchdog does it every 5 minutes (`./mount_volumes.sh`)
A volume shows as EDIT-1 or EDIT-2	Normal. Confirm it in the Volumes box. The mount script warns about duplicates; disconnect extra copies in Finder when convenient
Red: Removed from the index	The clip left the index (moved or deleted). Remove it, search again
Editor installer cannot reach the middle machine (Windows)	Check the middle PC is on, same network, and port 8000 is allowed; reprint the line with `.\clipstage.ps1 editor-kit`
Windows: "Typesense did not start"	`wsl -l -v` must list ClipStage as version 2; BIOS virtualization must be on; log `C:\ClipStage\typesense.log`
Windows: cannot download the Linux image	`wsl --install -d Ubuntu-24.04` then re-run the installer with `-WslDistro Ubuntu-24.04`
Mac: app will not open ("unidentified developer")	System Settings, Privacy and Security, Open Anyway (the app is built locally, not signed)
NAS volume shows FAILED	Wrong NAS address/login or share name; re-run with `--reconfigure` / `-Reconfigure`
Anything else	`./clipstage.sh status` or `.\clipstage.ps1 status`, then the logs `api.log` and `indexer.log`

13. Rollback

- Keep the old ClipStage folder and the backup from section 10 until v7 has run for a few days.
- The new `staged` table is additive. The old version ignores it, so rolling back does not damage the database.
- To go back: stop the services, restore the old folder (or reinstall v5.1.3) and your backed-up `.env` and `clipstage.db`, and reinstall the old editor app.
- Transition option: set `CLIPSTAGE_LEGACY_HOST_SYMLINKS=1` in `.env` and restart. The middle machine then also creates the old host links next to the new list.

14. What is verified, and what is not

	Status
Run and passing	16 Node tests (path map, status checks, the app's IPC with a stubbed Electron, local links, origin check, popup and navigation lock); the staging database functions (including upgrading a v6-dev table); syntax checks of Python, JavaScript, the page script and the bash installers
Written, not run	The API tests (`tests/test_api.py`, need pytest and the project's Python packages), the page tests (`tests/ui_platform.mjs`, need jsdom), the two Windows PowerShell installers (not parsed here)
Never run on real hardware	Drag into Final Cut Pro (one file and several), Leave in place for such drags, drag into Premiere / Resolve / Avid on Windows, the Mac local-links route, the duplicate-mount warning in `mount_volumes.sh`

Run the test checklist (section 11) on one editor computer of each type before rolling out to everyone.

15. Quick reference

Task	Mac	Windows
Install middle machine	`bash install-mac-host.sh`	`powershell -ExecutionPolicy Bypass -File .\install-win-host.ps1`
Install editor computer	`bash install-mac-editor.sh --host <ip>`	paste the line from `.\clipstage.ps1 editor-kit`
Status / restart / logs	`./clipstage.sh status | restart | logs`	`.\clipstage.ps1 status | restart | logs`
Index / stop index	`./clipstage.sh index | stop-index`	`.\clipstage.ps1 index | stop-index`
Backup	`./clipstage.sh backup`	`.\clipstage.ps1 backup`
Re-ask all questions	`--reconfigure`	`-Reconfigure`
Import old staging (Mac host)	`.venv/bin/python migrate_staging_to_db.py [--apply]`	not verified
Run the app tests	`cd clipstage-fcp-drag && npm test`	`cd clipstage-fcp-drag; npm test`

More detail: `INSTALL-QUICKSTART.md` (indexing, stopping an index, how Windows differs) and `V7-NOTES.md` (what changed in the code).